

HITTITES



A WARLIKE PEOPLE, known as the Hittites, flourished from 1600 to 1200 BC, when they had one of the most powerful armies of the ancient world. They settled in Anatolia (central Turkey) around 2000 BC, then established control over the area from their great fortified capital at Hattusas. Gradually, the Hittite kingdom expanded into Syria, where they clashed with Egypt, and the growing might of Assyria. Despite their fearsome reputation, the Hittites were astute politicians, and preferred diplomacy to armed conflict where possible. Eventually, attacks from outside forces, combined with famine, put an end to their empire.



The Hittite Empire covered most of Turkey and Anatolia at its height, c.1300 BC.

Teshub was often portrayed holding a weapon.

A three-pronged lightning fork



Teshub, the Hittite storm god

Chariot warfare

From 2000 BC the introduction of horses, the development of the bit, and strong, spoked wheels transformed the chariot from a humble cart pulled by asses, into a dangerous weapon which changed warfare in the Near East. The Hittites were masters of this weapon.



Diplomacy

The Hittites favoured diplomatic marriages to secure peace, especially with Egypt. For instance, after the Battle of Kadesh, a Hittite princess was married to a pharaoh. On another occasion, an Egyptian queen, possibly Tutankhamun's widow, wrote to the Hittite king asking to marry one of his sons.



Ramses II

Battle of Kadesh

The world's earliest battle that can be reconstructed was between the chariots of the Hittite king, Muwatallis, and the Egyptian Ramses II at Kadesh in 1286 BC. Chariots continued to be important to ancient armies for over 2000 years.



Ugarit

A wealthy trading city on the Mediterranean coast, Ugarit was a main area of conflict between the Hittites and the Egyptians because of its location. It was abandoned in the turmoil that destroyed the Hittite Empire. Archaeologists have unearthed one of the world's earliest cuneiform alphabets here.

Politics

Hittite rulers were supreme commanders of the army (and chief judges and high priests). The greatest king was Suppiluliumas I (r.1380–1346 BC), who conquered all Syria, between the Euphrates and the sea. Though he took this territory through military might, he kept it by bribing his Egyptian rivals with gold. Many Syrian gods were accepted by the Hittites as leading deities, including Teshub, who symbolized storms and the destruction of war.

Art and literature

Hittite myths emphasize divine warfare, and many feature Teshub defeating evil outside forces. In the remains of their hilltop capital at Hattusas (modern Boghazkoy, Turkey), stone reliefs in the city wall show helmeted warriors, and some of the many Hittite gods. Tiny figures, crafted in gold, have been found. These depict kings and gods, and wear the distinctive upturned boots of a mountain people.



Head-dress, indicating high status

Short-sleeved tunic

Upturned boots

Gold figurine, possibly of a Hittite king



Hittite wall relief

Neo-Hittites

The Syrian city-states belonging to the empire adopted Hittite hieroglyphics and art. After the collapse of the empire, this influence continued, and the cities became known as the Neo-Hittite states.

Food and drink

The main crops were barley and wheat, which were used for making bread and brewing beer. The Hittites also grew fruits, such as apples, figs, and apricots, and they made wine from grapes. Bees produced honey, and farmers raised sheep, oxen, and cattle.



Apple

Figs

Apricots

Timeline



Hittite warhorse

1600–1400 BC The first Hittite kingdom is established in Anatolia.

1595 BC King Mursili I sacks Babylon, but does not remain.

1550 BC The fortified Hittite capital is established at Hattusas.

c.1460 BC Tudhaliyas II begins conquests that establish last phase of empire.

1380–1346 BC Suppiluliumas commands a vast empire stretching from present-day western Turkey to north Syria. Hattusas (modern Boghazkoy) is the main cultural influence in the area.

1299 BC One of the earliest known battles takes place, between Hittite and Egyptian forces, at Kadesh.

1283 BC Peace treaties are signed between Hittites and Egyptians.

1200 BC The growth of the Assyrian Empire, forces invading from the north and west, and famine combine to destroy the Hittite Empire.

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